

Indian Physiography & Drainage

Himalaya, Peninsular block, Indo-Gangetic plains and drainage systems - India geography core.

Portion focus ~80% · Topic: geo-india

PYQ themes: Himalayan ranges · Peninsular plateaus · Drainage patterns · Passes · Coastal plains

Why this portion (PYQ lens)

Portion chance ~80%. Steady; parent geo-india ~77%.

Years appeared (synthesis): 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025

Why UPSC asks this

Region - feature matching is the backbone of India physical geography Prelims.

Syllabus framing

Portion chance ~80%. Steady; parent geo-india ~77%. This portion sits inside geo-india and centres on Indian physiography and drainage. Region - feature matching is the backbone of India physical geography Prelims.

Recurring PYQ angles: Himalayan ranges, Peninsular plateaus, Drainage patterns, Passes, Coastal plains. Approximate appearance years in the 2016-2025 educational synthesis: 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025. Use the chance percentage only to sequence study hours - it is not an official prediction.

Core map of Indian physiography and drainage

Himalayan divisions: Trans/Greater/Lesser/Siwalik longitudinal zonation. Syntaxial bends: NW and NE bends - map awareness.

Passes: Strategic/historical - select list not encyclopedia. Indo-Gangetic plain: Alluvial fertility and flood regimes.

Hold this core map as your elimination spine before memorising peripheral CA overlays.

Core concepts and definitions

Peninsular plateau: Old hard rock; Deccan traps; residual hills. Western vs Eastern Ghats: Continuity, elevation, rainfall contrasts.

Coastal plains: West narrower; east wider deltas narrative. Himalayan drainage: Antecedent/tectonic influences; snow-fed.

Institutions, processes and mechanisms

Peninsular drainage: Rain-fed; gentle gradients; east-flowing majors. West-flowing exceptions: Narmada/Tapi rift valleys - classic.

Ganga - Brahmaputra - Indus: System personalities. Godavari/Krishna/Kaveri/Mahanadi: Peninsular east-flowing set.

India angle and applied examples

Drainage patterns: Dendritic/trellis/radial - rock structure links. Water divides: Western Ghats divide idea.

Lakes: Wular, Chilika, Pulicat, Sambhar - type discrimination. Islands: Andaman-Nicobar tectonic; Lakshadweep coral.

Comparisons, linkages and discriminators

Thar desert edge: Physiographic transition. Doab concept: Land between rivers.

River interlinking debates: Conceptual - not scheme spam. Floodplains/khadar/bhangar: Alluvial terms.

India angle

Map practice weekly beats prose-only reading for this portion.

Question patterns and exam spine

Matching lists and statements on Indian physiography and drainage.

Revision spine: Definitions -> table -> India -> traps.

Eliminate anachronisms and category errors first, then test remaining options against table rows and must-remember triggers.

Trap watch-list (specific)

Avoid: All Himalayan rivers purely rain-fed. Avoid: Narmada east-flowing. Avoid: Eastern Ghats as continuous as Western. Avoid: Chilika as freshwater always.

Drainage contrast

Type | Cue

Himalayan rivers -- Snow+rain; long

Peninsular -- Rain-fed; graded

West-flowing -- Narmada/Tapi rifts

East-flowing majors -- Deltaic mouths

Map / list facts

- Major passes select
- Narmada rift
- Delta coasts
- Andaman vs Lakshadweep

Common traps

- x All Himalayan rivers purely rain-fed
- x Narmada east-flowing
- x Eastern Ghats as continuous as Western
- x Chilika as freshwater always

Must remember

- Himalayan zones
- W vs E Ghats
- Narmada/Tapi west
- Ganga system
- Dendritic etc.
- Island types

Quick revision checklist

- ☐ Reproduce table
- ☐ 5 must-remembers
- ☐ 3 traps
- ☐ India anchor
- ☐ 10 MCQs

Educational prioritisation heuristic - not an official UPSC prediction. (c) UPSC IAS Study Hub original notes.